300,000 People in the Path of Himalayan Disasters as Building Booms

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At least 300,000 people in parts of the Himalayan region could now be living in the path of possible disasters, a new study suggests. The true number could be much higher, because only one territory was studied. Nine researchers from the UK, Nepal, and India studied land up to 50 kilometers **downstream** from Himalayan rivers and around 1,360 **glacial lakes**, finding major development: more tourism facilities, **infrastructure**, and **real estate**. Pokhara, a tourism hub at the foot of the Himalayas, has grown a lot over 30 years to serve many more visitors. Mayor Dhana Raj Acharya says dealing with the risk from the Seti Gandaki River, which flows through the city, is a huge challenge. Many old buildings stand just 5 meters from the river banks, despite new rules requiring them to be further away. To the north, the Annapurna trekking region has also seen many more settlements along river banks, some hit by recent floods and landslides. **Hydropower plants** have also risen along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers. August floods in Nepal later killed more than 1,400 people.

Word Treasure

glacial lakes -- Glacial lakes are lakes formed by melting ice from glaciers.

infrastructure -- Infrastructure means the basic buildings, roads, and systems a place needs to work.

real estate -- Real estate means land and the buildings on it that can be bought and sold.

hydropower plants -- Hydropower plants make electricity using the power of flowing water.

downstream -- Downstream means in the direction a river flows, away from its source.

Background you need

The Himalayas are a high mountain region where rivers and lakes fed by ice and snow flow down into valleys.

When floods or landslides happen, water and rock can rush downstream and reach towns built near rivers.

Building homes, hotels, and power plants close to river banks puts more people in the path of such disasters.

Break it down

WHO: Nine researchers from the UK, Nepal, and India, and the people living and visiting in the Himalayan region

WHAT: A building boom near rivers and glacial lakes has put more people in the path of possible disasters

WHERE: The Himalayan region, including Pokhara, the Annapurna trekking region, and the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers

WHY: Tourism facilities, infrastructure, real estate, and hydropower plants have grown along river banks, close to flood and landslide danger

Why it matters

Learning why homes should not be built too close to rivers can help you understand why safe places to live and play matter, even on a family trip to the mountains.

Test what you remember

1. Who carried out the study of the Himalayan region?

- (A) Tourists visiting Annapurna
- (B) Workers at a hydropower plant
- (C) The mayor of Pokhara alone
- (D) Nine researchers from the UK, Nepal, and India

2. What kind of place is Pokhara?

- (A) A tourism hub at the foot of the Himalayas
- (B) An island port
- (C) A desert oasis
- (D) A capital city

3. Which river flows through Pokhara?

- (A) The Bhotekoshi River
- (B) The Annapurna River
- (C) The Trishuli River
- (D) The Seti Gandaki River

4. How close to the river banks do many old buildings in Pokhara stand?

- (A) 5 meters
- (B) 50 meters
- (C) 30 meters
- (D) 500 meters

5. What has happened in the Annapurna trekking region?

- (A) Many more settlements have appeared along river banks, some hit by floods and landslides
- (B) All the rivers have dried up
- (C) Tourism has stopped completely
- (D) The mountains have stopped growing

6. What has risen along the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli rivers?

- (A) Glacial lakes
- (B) Hydropower plants
- (C) Schools for tourists
- (D) Mountain railways

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: D 4: A 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Researchers: Many people could now be living in the path of possible disasters, and the true number could be much higher because only one territory was studied.

2. Mayor Dhana Raj Acharya: Dealing with the risk from the Seti Gandaki River is a huge challenge.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):